

Paywall placement

Week 7, Lecture 1 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- Gating after taste: why placing the paywall after value beats placing it at the door
- The comprehension score as the natural paywall moment for LangoBee
- Upgrade triggers: the four placement strategies and how to choose
- Where LangoBee's current gate sits and what the PostHog data shows
- One change that could turn zero trials into measurable conversion

Gating after taste

The front door vs the aha moment

Two places a paywall can sit:

- **Front door:** payment ask before the user has experienced anything. Credit card required to start. LangoBee today.
- **After the aha moment:** payment ask immediately after the user has seen a personal, specific result. One comprehension score. One vocabulary session.

The front-door placement assumes the landing page carries all the persuasion. The aha-moment placement lets the product do it.

(Meinertzhagen, 2023)

What the case studies show

RevenueCat tracked apps that moved their paywall from the front door to immediately after the aha moment:

- Greg (plant care app): signup-to-trial conversion 3% → 15% after the move
- Rootd (anxiety app): 5x revenue increase with the same tactic

The mechanism: users who have seen the product work have a concrete reason to pay. Users who have not seen the product work have only the promise in the copy.

(Meinertzhagen, 2023)

What "demonstrated value" means

Jake Mor's framing: "The most important thing is getting a user to an aha moment as quickly as possible." (Cited in Meinertzhagen, 2023)

Demonstrated value is specific and personal:

- Not: "LangoBee has 17,440 videos"
- Not: "Spanish learners improve with comprehensible input"
- Yes: "You know 74% of the words in this video. 12 words are new."

The comprehension score is the moment demonstrated value exists for this user, about their vocabulary, right now.

The comprehension score as the
paywall moment

Why the comprehension score is the right gate

LangoBee's word-level status tracking produces a per-video comprehension score. This score is unique to each user. It reflects their specific vocabulary, not a generic difficulty rating.

The score is visible after a user has:

1. Created an account
2. Started a video or reading
3. Received the result

That sequence takes under 5 minutes. The paywall should fire after step 3, not before step 1.

LangoBee's current gate: before step 1

As of June 2026:

- Credit card required before trial starts
- Zero real users have entered the trial funnel (zero trial_started events)
- 24% of real signups ever return
- word_lookup_opened is the top product action: 5,225 events in 30 days

The engagement signal is there. The trial funnel is not. The gap is placement.

(June 2026 snapshot)

The word tap as the earlier signal

word_lookup_opened is the most frequent product action. It fires when a user taps a word they do not know.

This event is earlier than the comprehension score and just as personal. A user who has tapped a word has:

- Encountered target-language content
- Identified a gap in their knowledge
- Asked the product to help

That is the aha moment. The paywall could fire here. The comprehension score is a second, slightly later option with more emotional weight.

The four placement strategies

Four strategies, one choice

Parizek (2024) names four paywall placement strategies:

1. **Onboarding:** ~50% of all trial starts; fires at the end of first-run onboarding before the user reaches the core product
2. **Contextual:** fires when the user hits a premium-only feature or completes a value moment
3. **Buy-now:** fires on a dedicated pricing or upgrade screen the user navigates to
4. **Campaign:** fires via push, email, or in-app message after inaction

Most top-performing apps use a combination. The default for a pre-revenue app: start with contextual.

(Parizek, 2024)

Why contextual fits LangoBee now

Fires before the user has seen the product.
High volume, low trust. Appropriate once acquisition is at scale.

Fires after the comprehension score or first word tap. User has a personal result.
Appropriate for a pre-revenue product testing whether demonstrated value converts.

Onboarding placement

Contextual placement

The goal is one data point: does a user who has seen their score convert to a trial at a higher rate than a user who has not?
Contextual placement produces that test.
Onboarding placement does not.

"The most important thing is getting a user to an aha moment as quickly as possible."

Jake Mor, cited in Peter Meinertzhagen (2023)

Optimizing Paywall Placement, RevenueCat

The RICE framework for choosing which trigger first

Parizek (2024) recommends RICE scoring for paywall test prioritization:

- **Reach:** how many users hit this moment per month?
- **Impact:** how much does this moment correlate with trial conversion?
- **Confidence:** what evidence exists for the impact estimate?
- **Effort:** how many days to implement?

For LangoBee: word_lookup_opened has the highest reach (5,225/30d). Comprehension score has the highest impact hypothesis. Effort is similar. Run comprehension-score first.

Take-aways

1. Placing the paywall before demonstrated value produces low trial conversion because the user has no personal reason to pay. LangoBee's current gate is at the door, before any value.
2. The comprehension score is LangoBee's strongest demonstrated-value moment: it is personal, specific, and visible within the first session.
3. Contextual placement (trigger fires after the comprehension score or first word tap) is the right first move for a pre-revenue product.
4. The goal of moving the paywall is not to trick users into trials. It is to ask for payment after the product has earned the question.

What's next

- **Reading:** "Week 7: Paywall placement and the trial-to-paid funnel" at [/c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk07](#)
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** Trial to paid: nurture sequence, cancellation diagnosis, dunning basics, first-dollar psychology
- **Section this week:** Audit the live paywall: stranger walk, trigger map, PostHog funnel diagnosis
- **HW3:** In flight, due week 8